explained that although he was now on his way to the Delhi Assembly and had ‘travelled far away towards my destination’, the fact was that ‘one thing has continued to prick my heart’, and ‘this is that my own brother misunderstood me and levelled a very serious charge of weakness towards me’. He makes it clear to him that he is committed to ‘sacrifice in the true sense of the word’.

It is interesting that he does not deny that he is not partial to love. On the contrary, he extols the virtues of love and disabuses Sukhdev of the notion that it is a source of weakness. He begins with the observation that ‘in the context of discussing someone’s character, one thing that is worth thinking about is if love has ever proved to be helpful to any person. Let me answer this today – yes it did, for Mazzini’. He gives the example of Mazzini because of his ‘first unsuccessful rebellion’, which had left him with ‘the grief of heart-wrenching failure, and the memory of martyred comrades’. Bhagat Singh explains of Mazzini how, in the circumstances, ‘he could have either gone mad or committed suicide, but with a letter from his beloved, he became not only as strong as others, but stronger than everybody else’. Against this backdrop, Bhagat Singh proceeds to speak of love as ‘a very sweet human emotion. Love is never a bestial passion’. In fact, ‘the character of a person is always elevated by love . . .’. Of girls who fall in love, he states ‘you cannot call these girls mad’ before proclaiming that ‘true love can never be created. It wells up by itself when no one can predict’.[9] There is then an extraordinary statement where he clearly endorses the falling in love by revolutionaries, in terms that ‘it is not bad in modern times; rather, it is good and beneficial for man’. Indeed, despite his own strict religious family background, he finds himself reprimanding Sukhdev for his straight-laced, prudish and rather spartan outlook on love. As he explains, ‘we cannot adopt the Arya Samaj model of puritan morality’ and asks him ‘to temper the extreme idealism that you have’. One may wonder here whether Bhagat Singh makes an admission here of his own love when he admonishes Sukhdev with the words, ‘Don’t be cold to those who lag behind and *fall prey to a disease like mine*; don’t heighten their pain by scolding them, because they need your sympathy.’ Such an